

The Iron Barrier and the Promise of the Last Day

Based on Qur'an, Surah Al-Kahf (18) : 96-98

Dhul-Qarnayn began to build. He said, "Bring me sheets of iron." The iron was gathered until, when it had been levelled to fill the gap between the two mountains, he said, "Blow with the bellows." So they blew until the iron glowed red like fire. Then he said, "Bring me molten copper that I may pour over it," so that the iron and copper fused into an immensely strong wall.

With that barrier, Gog and Magog were no longer able to climb over it, for its height and smoothness, nor able to bore through it, for its thickness and solidity. Their corruption against that weak people was held back.

Yet Dhul-Qarnayn did not attribute the success to himself. He said, "This is a mercy from my Lord." He ascribed all his strength and the fruit of his labour to God's favour alone. Then he reminded them that even the strongest wall has an appointed term: "But when the promise of my Lord comes, He will level it to the ground; and the promise of my Lord is ever true."

That barrier, however solid, will be brought down by God as the Last Day approaches, as one of His signs. Everything humankind builds will come to an end, and only God's promise is certain to be fulfilled.

Reflection: Effort and means must be pursued, but success is God's mercy, not the product of one's own greatness. Dhul-Qarnayn built the strongest of walls, then called it "a mercy from my Lord" and remembered that it too would fall in its time. This is the manner of a believer: to strive to the utmost, to rely wholly upon God, and never to forget that the world and all its structures will end on the promised Day.

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